> under the neighbouring seven houses, all of which we had rented, breaching walls and digging through the earth. Over the course of three months, they dug through seven walls, one after another, until they reached a side-gulli near the bazaar.[f]

Leaving a faithful follower to take his place in his bed and disguised as a wandering dervish – 'I polished my body and face with ashes, and made my hair messy with dreadlocks, covering it with a black turban' – Shuja fled through the tunnel with two aides. They then made their way through the city past 'infidel guards and other malevolent individuals who were made deaf and blind by God'.

> At last we reached the main drain of the Fort, which at this season was dry. It was dark and narrow and difficult to pass through, but we were determined to get out, and commending ourselves to God and His Prophet, pushed through, getting scratched and bloodied on the way. Eventually we emerged on to the riverbank. There, servants were waiting with suitable clothes; they had also pre-paid for the boatmen and his skiff. We quickly embarked and crossed to the far side of the river. Not for a moment did we feel the discomforts and dangers of the road, as we rode and occasionally went on foot, thinking neither of food nor sleep . . . So it was that we escaped naked, with our bare existence from Lahore. But we had no material, no funds, no supplies, so were soon reduced again to a state of near-despair.[10g]

Within a few months of his escape from Lahore, Shah Shuja made his first attempt to recover his kingdom.

Aligning himself with Ranjit Singh's enemies among the disaffected rajahs of the Punjab Hills, Shuja planned to gather a small army, make a surprise raid on Kashmir and seize the valley. It was a smart move, and could have provided a rich base from which to begin the reconquest of his lost throne – for, as William Fraser observed, Shuja was still 'beloved as a sovereign for his mellowness, leniency and liberality'.[11] Moreover the political timing was impeccable: in the aftermath of Ranjit Singh's raid to free Shuja, the Kashmir Valley was without a clear ruler and was disputed by several powers. But one thing Shah Shuja consistently lacked in his campaigning life was that quality which Napoleon famously remarked was most important for a general: luck.

The first disaster occurred when Shuja tried to get his finances in order and despatched a man to Lahore to bring the 150,000 rupees that he had deposited with the money-changers of the city. Ranjit Singh found out about the plan through his spies, intercepted the money and deposited it in his own treasury.[12] Raising more money led to delays, giving Kashmir's